Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Ruth

Ruth 1:1

- The judges led Israel from Joshua's death (around 1376 or 1200 BC) until Saul became king (around 1050 BC). The events in the Book of Ruth happened around 1100 BC.
- Drought often caused famine in Israel's hill country.
- Bethlehem was a small town in northern Judah's hill country.
- Moab, southeast of Judah, sometimes had enough rain when Judah did not.

Ruth 1:2

Ephrathites belonged to the Ephrathah clan, which was based in Bethlehem, Judah (see Genesis 35:19; 1 Chronicles 4:4).

Ruth 1:4

Kilion married Orpah, and Mahlon married Ruth (see Ruth 4:10).

Ruth 1:5

Naomi was left (literally the woman was bereft): Naomi faced deep emotional pain. She also lacked financial support, and without heirs, she had no hope for her family's future.

Ruth 1:6

The Hebrew verb for "giving" is also used in Ruth 4:13 as "enabled." These two mentions of God's actions frame the story with similar phrases, known as an inclusio or literary "bookends." God provides good things, like food and children, and he works behind the scenes in everyday life.

Ruth 1:8

They had probably gone only a short distance when Naomi released Ruth and Orpah to return to their mothers' homes.

Ruth 1:9

Naomi speaks the first blessing in the book.

Ruth 1:14

Ruth clung to her: The Hebrew verb here shows how strong Ruth's love was for her mother-in-law. It is the same word used to describe a man being "joined to" his wife (Genesis 2:24) and to describe a person staying faithful to the Lord (Deuteronomy 4:4; 10:20; Joshua 22:5).

Ruth 1:15

and her gods: Every nation believed in its own local god. Naomi thought Ruth would keep worshiping Moabite gods.

Ruth 1:16–17

Ruth made a promise in the name of the Lord to show her strong commitment to Israel's God (see Ruth 2:11–12) and to Naomi.

Ruth 1:20

Almighty translates the Hebrew word shadday, which shows God's strength and provision. Naomi's complaint was genuine, but God gave her exactly what she needed (see Ruth 4:14–17).

Ruth 1:22

The barley harvest began between late March and mid-April on our calendar.

Ruth 2:1

Boaz was a relative of Elimelech, so he could be a family redeemer for the widows Ruth and Naomi (see study note on Judges2:20).

Ruth 2:2

glean heads of grain: Harvesters were to leave some grain for the poor to gather (see Leviticus 19:9–10; 23:22; Deuteronomy 24:19–22). God ensured the poor had food.

Ruth 2:3

she happened to come to: Ruth chose a field seemingly at random to gather leftover grain. God uses ordinary choices to help those who trust him.

Ruth 2:5

Boaz saw Ruth as a young woman suitable for marriage (Hebrew na'arah).

Ruth 2:7

in the shelter: Many farmers in Israel's hill country built shelters next to their fields for the harvest. Workers used these shelters for shade during lunch or other breaks in the long, hard workday. You can still see these shelters in parts of the hill country.

Ruth 2:8–9

- Boaz gave Ruth the special privilege of gleaning right behind the young women. After the men cut the grain and tied it in small bundles, the women gathered the bundles into larger sheaves. The Torah did not require farmers to allow gleaners into the fields until they took the sheaves to the threshing floor.
- I have ordered the young men not to touch you: Boaz assured Ruth that no one under his authority would taunt her or try to drive her away from his fields, even though she was there before the proper time for gleaners.
- go and drink from the jars: Boaz's generosity saved Ruth the trouble of drawing her own water.

Ruth 2:13

your maidservant: By using this term, Ruth showed she was lower in status than Boaz's servants.

Ruth 2:14

Boaz showed great hospitality by sharing his meal with Ruth, going above and beyond what was expected.

Ruth 2:15–16

Boaz's instructions to his workers after lunch made Ruth's gleaning much more productive. Boaz gave Ruth more than the gleaning law required.

Ruth 2:18

Ruth was careful and generous when she gave Naomi the leftover roasted grain.

Ruth 2:19

glean: Ruth usually could not gather as much as an ephah of barley, which is about two-thirds of a bushel.

Ruth 2:20

kinsman-redeemers (Hebrew go'el): The law required the go'el, the closest male relative, to assist a family member facing financial difficulties (see "The Family Redeemer" Theme Note; see also study note on Leviticus 25:25).

Ruth 2:21

The author calls Ruth "Ruth the Moabite" five times (Ruth 1:22; 2:2, 21; 4:5, 10). This reminds us that Ruth was not an Israelite.

Ruth 3:1

a resting place: Naomi used a similar word in Ruth 1:9 when she prayed for Ruth and Orpah. Now she suggested a plan that might encourage Boaz to help Ruth.

Ruth 3:2

- As a close relative, Boaz might serve as a redeemer for Ruth and Naomi (see study notes on Ruth 2:20; 3:9).
- The threshing floor was a flat surface made of stone or hardened earth. The farmer spread sheaves of grain over it and beat them to separate the grain from the straw. Then the farmer would winnow by tossing the mixed straw and grain into the air with a wooden fork or shovel. The breeze carried the lighter straw and chaff away, while the heavier grains fell back to the threshing floor.

Ruth 3:3

wash yourself: Ruth likely washed herself with a cloth dipped in water. Only wealthy people had facilities for full immersion. Bathing was not a daily routine; it was for special occasions.

Ruth 3:4

Ruth uncovered Boaz's feet to wake him up.

Ruth 3:7

he went to lie down: The owner slept at the threshing floor to prevent small thefts.

Ruth 3:8

was startled (literally He was terrified): Boaz realized a woman was at his feet, but he did not know her identity or reason for being there.

Ruth 3:9

- your servant: Ruth intentionally identified herself with the female workers.
- Spread the corner of your garment over me: This was Ruth's way of asking Boaz to marry her (compare Ezekiel 16:8).
- Ruth appealed to Boaz's role as a family redeemer (Hebrew go'el) to convince him to marry her (see Ruth 4:5; "The Family Redeemer" Theme Note).

Ruth 3:10

You have shown more kindness: Ruth did not have to go to Bethlehem with Naomi. She was not required to

marry into Elimelech's family or give them an heir to the land (see Ruth 4:5).

Ruth 3:11

whatever you request: Boaz agreed to help Ruth. Some interpreters see Boaz's statement as a promise to marry Ruth (see also study note on Ruth 4:5). Most believe it means Boaz would help Ruth and Naomi by giving the closer relative the chance to act as family redeemer before he did (Ruth 4:1–12). By choosing to be the family redeemer for Ruth and Naomi, Boaz became a precursor to Jesus.

Ruth 3:12–13

Another man was more closely related to Elimelech than Boaz. He had the first right to act as the family redeemer and, according to most interpreters, to marry Ruth.

Ruth 3:15

six measures: There were two scoop sizes. The smaller measure, the omer, was one-tenth of an ephah (about eight cups or two quarts). The larger measure, the seah, was one-third of an ephah (about 26 2/3 cups or around seven quarts). The larger amount is more likely and shows a very generous gift, twice what Ruth gathered on her first day (Ruth 2:17). It was a significant sign of good faith.

Ruth 4:1

- Most legal transactions, like property transfers, happened at the town gate.
- friend: Boaz may have used the man's name, but the author of Ruth did not.

Ruth 4:3

Naomi…is selling the piece of land: Naomi likely did not control Elimelech's ancestral land, but she had legal ownership. She was selling the right to redeem, or buy back, the land from its current user.

Ruth 4:4

- redeem it: The law required a close relative, known as the family redeemer, to buy land when a landowner needed to sell it (see Leviticus 25:23–34). This practice kept land within the family. The redeemer acted as a caretaker for the land until the struggling landowner could recover financially and buy it back.
- I will redeem it: The relative saw a great opportunity —there was no male heir and no sign there would be one. He could add the land to his own estate while fulfilling his family duty.

Ruth 4:5

On the day you buy the land…you must also acquire the widow of the deceased: In Hebrew manuscripts, the verse reads I buy, but a scribal correction in the margin reads you buy, differing by one letter. The scribe believed you buy was the original text, suggesting an error in the main text. Some think I buy is the original, indicating Boaz and Ruth's marriage was already planned (see study note on Judges 3:11). However, most translators believe you buy is original because:

1. The scribe thought you buy was correct
2. Most ancient translations of Ruth which are older than our Hebrew copies, also read you buy
3. An earlier scribe might have mistakenly used I have acquired from Ruth 4:10 instead of you buy

This ensures Ruth can have children to continue her husband's name and keep the land in the family, drawing from Deuteronomy 25:7. Boaz linked the duties of a family redeemer (see study notes Ruth 2:20; Leviticus 25:25) with those of a brother-in-law (Latin "levir") to provide an heir for a deceased brother (see Deuteronomy 25:5–10 for levirate marriage; compare Genesis 38). There is no exact precedent for Boaz's legal action. The duty of the "levir" in Deuteronomy 25:5–10 did not apply here, as neither Boaz nor the other kinsman was Elimelech's brother, and Ruth was not Elimelech's widow. Boaz used the spirit of the law about the go'el (family redeemer) to create a moral, if not legal, duty to act as "levir" and provide an heir to inherit the land (see study note on Leviticus 25:25). Land ownership and providing an heir were closely linked in ancient Israel (compare Numbers 27:1–11). Since Naomi was too old to have children, Ruth, Elimelech's son's widow, would be the mother of such an heir. This move surprised the other kinsman (Ruth 4:6), but Boaz's argument, though perhaps new, was accepted as valid.

Ruth 4:6

- I cannot redeem it myself: Adding Ruth to the deal changed everything for the other relative.
- I would jeopardize my own inheritance: If he bought the land, married Ruth, and raised an heir for Elimelech, he might invest many resources only to lose control of the new land. He might not have enough to maintain his own land. If he failed to have a second son with Ruth as his own heir, his land would go to Elimelech's heir, and his own name would

disappear. Even if this relative acquired the land without Ruth (see study notes on Ruth 3:11; 4:5), he might still lose his investment to Ruth's heir. By trying to protect his own name, this man became the nameless one who refused to help his close relative.

Ruth 4:7

in former times: The Book of Ruth was not written right after the events happened. By the time it was written, most people had forgotten the custom of removing a sandal and its meaning. The transfer of a sandal symbolized transferring the right to buy and redeem land. See also Deuteronomy 25:9 for a similar, but not identical, custom related to levirate marriage. In both cases, the sandal signified the right of redemption.

Ruth 4:10

Moreover: Boaz planned to have a child for Mahlon, the first son. This child would continue the family name of her deceased husband and inherit his land.

Ruth 4:11

- Rachel and Leah, Jacob's two wives, were the mothers of Israel.
- Ephrathah: See study note on Ruth 1:2.

Ruth 4:12

Like Ruth, Tamar was a foreigner. She became the mother of Perez and Zerah, who were ancestors of Judah's descendants.

Ruth 4:13

the LORD enabled her: See study note on Ruth 1:6.

Ruth 4:14

This child became the family Naomi lost when her two sons died in Moab. The town's women saw that this child completed Naomi's redemption.

Ruth 4:15

sustain you in your old age (literally cause your old age to be full): With Obed's birth, Naomi's life became full again (compare Ruth 1:21).

Ruth 4:18–22

The book of Ruth ends with a genealogy of ten generations, from Perez, the son of Judah (Jacob's son), to David, the grandson of Obed. This story is not only one of the world's great tales but also details the family history of David, Israel's greatest king. The fact that Ruth and Boaz were ancestors of Israel's greatest king is a major reason for including this small book in the Old Testament.